

star power to humanitarian effect, even exploiting their own children when they have to (selling the first pictures of their twins Knox Leon and Vivienne Marcheline to *People* magazine for \$14 million) but in India, the intent is more commercial. Even for covert couples such as Salman Khan and Katrina Kaif who have appeared together four times on reality shows, two of them on the all-important *10 Ka Dum* on Sony. They have other ways of keeping the public interest piqued. She will promise a watch to journalists who won't ask her Salman questions (they do), while his minions make sure bhabhi's favourite biryani is ordered in time.

But Saifina, a name that makes both cringe, is the awesome twosome that has redefined star couples in Bollywood, despite being in two recent turkeys together, *Tashan* and *Roadside Romeo*. He's a prince, she's a princess. He's posh and she's chic.



FOTOCORP

He has a back story, with two children and an Italian ex. She's got all the anxieties of a contemporary fashionista, from scary skinny issues to SMS insecurities. Despite the 10-year age gap, the two-year relationship benefits them both. So much so that Kareena is the invisible star of her former director Imtiaz Ali's next with Deepika Padukone and Saif, *Love Aaj Kal*.

Padukone and Ranbir Kapoor are another couple who happily gush about fluff stuff to glossies, and the almost-neighbours are often seen out on dinners. But Kapoor, who's rejected 15 brand endorsements in the past six months, is in no hurry to be defined by his relationship and steadfastly refuses offers to repeat their Pepsi experience. Some like Abhishek and Aishwarya are just waiting for the price to be right, though not only is she his co-star in three forthcoming movies (Mani Ratnam's *Ravana*, Rajiv Menon's *Dhun*, and Abhinay Deo's untitled next) but they also tend to treat global events such as the Unforgettable Tour and the MAA weekend as private celebratory parties. Movies starring them together have automatic newsworthiness, but they are

COVERT COUPLE

SALMAN KHAN & KATRINA KAIF

If he's obsessed with laughing at her Hindi in public, she's carefully casual with Bollywood's most toxic bachelor.

FOTOCORP

GENES POOLED

SAIF ALI KHAN & KAREENA KAPOOR

He tattooed her name on his forearm, she made size zero a national fad. He drives down to Ladakh for her birthday, she hosts a party at Four Seasons for him.

not above enhancing it, such as using the release of *Guru* to announce their engagement and launching the publicity of *Sarkar Raj* on their first wedding anniversary.

Ajay Devgan and Kajol don't have the same aura, but they haven't done too badly in the money stakes, making Rs 2.5-3 crore a piece in endorsing Whirlpool and Tata Indicom for two years, and Rs 40 crore in hosting a show on Zee TV, *Rock N Roll Family*, along with mother-in-law, former star Tanuja. The peer pressure is so intense that even the non-actor halves have to perform. So Hrithik Roshan and Suzanne Khan turn up in coordinated colours (advised usually by stylist Anaita Shroff Adajania) for candlelight AIDS memorials or to promote one-stop destinations for weddings. All this while gazing adoringly into each other's eyes even as they ignore rumours of break-ups, and it's easy to see why being a fabloid couple is a full-time profession. Ask Raj Kundra. As Shilpa Shetty's husband-in-training, the London-based businessman has already gifted her an IPL team, a flat in south Kensington and a birthday party complete with a girl band and pictures in *OK!*. It's all in the aid of google-ability. After all, it's the google hits that put Saif and Kareena at the top of the couple pecking order, getting him Rs 2 crore a year and her Rs 1 crore a year. Plus premium. And it's the google hits that almost snagged John Abraham the Reebok ad with Bipasha Basu, until M.S. Dhoni seemed hotter. In Bollywood, remember, the sum of individuals is greater than the parts. ■

